

Miracles that point to Jesus

Installation of Canons at Manchester Cathedral

Sunday, 5 October 2025

John 9

May Christ, who makes the deaf to hear his word, and who calls the blind to behold their Saviour, open our eyes to his truth, and our hearts to his grace. Amen.

Friends, in our reading from John 9 we hear the extraordinary story of Jesus healing a man who was blind from birth. In today's world, people respond to a story like this in different ways. Some hear it as a parable or allegory — a story that points to deeper truths. Some dismiss it altogether — assuming such things can't possibly be true. And some find themselves wondering — what if it really did happen, and if so, what might that mean for us? But for me, I believe in miracles because I once witnessed one at first hand.

Exactly thirty-seven years ago I had only just come to Christian faith through the witness of friends at university. I was studying mathematics — wrestling with prime numbers and Fourier transformations — and hearing the natural testimony of Christian friends alongside my own questions about life. Those strands came together, and I found myself becoming a Christian, a disciple of Jesus Christ, in May 1988.

In October, just six months into my new faith, I went away with friends on a Christian Union house party. Although I was full of enthusiasm, and I'd already read most of the Bible, I was still short on Christian wisdom. But I was ready to believe God could do anything.

During one of the sessions, we broke into small groups to pray. Usually, the requests were about essays or exams, or — in the case of sad geeks like me — prayers about finding a girlfriend. I was in a group with my friend Mark, who asked for prayers to decide if he should pursue a vocation in the Civil Service.

One thing to know about Mark is that he had been blind in one eye from birth. He had enough sight to live a full life, but in that one eye he had no vision at all.

As we began to pray for him about his career, the words that slipped out were: 'Dear Jesus, please help Mark to see clearly the way ahead.' There was a pause. Then suddenly Mark began shouting and jumping round the room. At first, we couldn't make out what he was saying — but soon it was unmistakable: 'I can see! I can see!' It was, quite simply, an impossible miracle — sight where there had never been sight before.

The scene was almost comical. Mark — or was it Jesus? — was disturbing the quiet and reverence of the prayer meeting. In fact, we were actually asked to leave because we were distracting others from their prayers. Which was more than a little ironic, especially as only a few minutes earlier we had sung the hymn *O for a Thousand Tongues to Sing* by Charles Wesley — the hymn that calls out, ‘ye blind, behold your Saviour come’.

And the best part? All these years later, Mark can still see in both eyes.

For a more recent story, last year I was teaching a class on global mission and we connected on Zoom to my friend Patrick in Hyderabad, India. One of my UK students asked him: how do people where you are come to faith? I think the student was expecting to hear about Alpha courses or leaflets.

For Patrick the answer was obvious: most people in his church became Christians through a miraculous healing, or through a dream in which they saw Jesus or an angel. Although not the UK experience, for Patrick this was normal Christianity.

Closer to home, my friend Chloe has just completed a PhD study on prayer healings in Wales, between 2015 and 2020. She has collected and verified over 600 stories of people healed through Christian prayer. A man’s crushed feet healed when children prayed in a garden; a torn knee healed at Cardiff Airport while someone prayed before a flight; a bad back eased during a pedicure as a customer prayed.

Some of the stories were of smaller conditions — allergies, broken toes, headaches. Others were major conditions: tumours, cancers, blindness, long-term disabilities. One teenage girl had a tumour on her optic nerve and was told she would go blind; after prayer, the tumour disappeared. Another, sent home with no hope after cancer had spread, was healed — and later gave birth to a child.

Chloe sums it up like this: ‘in Wales today, ordinary Christians are reporting Jesus doing his healing work in everyday places’.

We carry reports like these — from Scripture and from our own experience and contacts — carefully, especially this week as we grieve in Manchester for those killed at the Heaton Park Hebrew Congregation synagogue, not far from here. We hold them gently, knowing that many do not experience healing in this way, in this present time — the kingdom of God has come, and is growing among us, yet it will not be complete until Christ returns.

But we also carry them with faith that grows as we come to know more deeply the God who still shows love to people today: forgiving sin, mending broken lives, giving hope, drawing people to worship Jesus Christ — and sometimes doing extraordinary miracles.

When we turn to John 9, the story of the man born blind, we enter one of the most remarkable chapters in this Gospel. It runs the full length of forty-one verses, because John is not simply giving us a healing report. He is showing how a miracle becomes a sign — a sign that points to who Jesus is, and one that sets in motion conflict, testimony, rejection, and faith.

Jesus never reduces this blind man to his condition. He does not use him as an exhibit or treat him as a moral lesson. He sees him as a person loved by God. And in the way John tells it, even the smallest details carry meaning. He draws our attention to where the healing takes place — at the Pool of Siloam. Even the name of the pool matters: Siloam means ‘Sent’, *shālah* in Hebrew. This is no throwaway detail; it links the whole story to the language of mission. Here the chapter crystallises John’s ‘sent-one’ theology: Jesus, sent from the Father, now sends the healed man as witness — a pattern that anticipates the church’s own calling to be sent into the world.

Jesus himself says in this chapter, ‘We must do the works of him who sent me...’ (v4). He is the one sent from the Father, and now he sends the blind man to the ‘Pool of Sent’. The man is healed, and immediately he is sent again — sent back to his neighbours, sent before the Pharisees, sent as a witness to Christ. To encounter Jesus is to be sent. And the church that bears his name is apostolic — a church that is sent. Healing is not the end of the story. It makes disciples, restores dignity, and sends people out to tell what God has done. And the reason this sending matters so deeply is that Jesus himself reveals what kind of sending it is: he is the light of the world.

John makes the allegory clear: blindness and sight are not only physical but spiritual. The Pharisees, who think they see, are blind; the man, who was blind, now sees both physically and spiritually. Healing here is the gateway to faith. The man’s eyes are opened, and then his heart is opened too. The sign points to Jesus, who declares, ‘I am the light of the world’. Light reveals, light awakens, light draws us out of darkness — into faith.

This is the purpose of the miracle — not only to restore sight, but to show us who Jesus is. And when Jesus gives light, it is never abstract; it always restores people in concrete ways, though not without cost.

The healing restores more than sight. It restores the man’s agency, dignity, and place in society. No longer dependent on his parents, no longer excluded from the synagogue, he becomes a disciple in his own right. Healing resets his life.

Yet this restoration comes at a cost: the man is expelled from the synagogue. Following Jesus may mean rejection by one’s community.

Like my friend Patrick — the one who regularly sees healing and dreams — he also knows the cost of following Jesus far more than we do in the West. When I first met him, his associate minister and the minister's wife had been shot as they left church, after ignoring warnings to stop speaking about Jesus.

Yet notice the pastoral note at the end: 'Jesus heard that they had thrown him out, and when he found him...' Jesus cares.

The healing in John 9 is more than restoration — it is awakening. The man who once begged now bears witness; the one who once groped in darkness now recognises the light of the world. Every sign Jesus performs has this same purpose: to lead a person to faith, to open not only the eyes but the heart.

That same work of God continues today. Across the Church something gentle yet real is stirring — not loud or spectacular, but steady and sincere. This year, across our nation, many are quietly coming to faith: people who have never been to church, some drawn by dreams of Jesus or by moments they can't explain, others simply curious, walking through the cathedral doors for the first time and not knowing quite why they have come. Some call it a 'quiet revival'; perhaps it is simply that Jesus, the light of the world, is still opening eyes today.

And with it comes a growing openness to the work of the Holy Spirit — to his power to heal bodies, mend hearts, and open eyes to faith. Perhaps God is calling his Church to a deeper awareness and a fuller response: to trust again that the same Spirit who worked in John 9 still works today, through both the miracle of healing and the greater miracle of people coming to see Jesus Christ as Saviour and Lord.

Let us end with Charles Wesley, whom I have mentioned several times. He described his own awakening to faith with these words in his journal: 'I now found myself at peace with God, and rejoiced in hope of loving Christ. I saw that by faith I stood; ... The Spirit of God chased away the darkness of my unbelief.'

And in a hymn written in celebration one year later:

He speaks, and listening to his voice, new life the dead receive; the mournful,
broken hearts rejoice, the humble poor believe. Hear him, ye deaf; his praise, ye
dumb, your loosen'd tongues employ; ye blind, behold your Saviour come; and
leap, ye lame, for joy.

Amen.